Stardust - Terra Deleta: Game Budget

Zoud GameLab Financial Literacy Jam. Amounts spent come from Rise Solutions' receipts; the 12-month plan uses typical market rates as of late 2026, as ranges to be confirmed with quotes.

1. Where the project stands

Already built and running: the Godot app (flight, true-scale solar system, debris fields, scanner, collecting and unloading, the live market and blueprint auctions, the Starship Library, the Starship Bank with savings, term deposits, loans and savings goals, the Desk ledger, cargo-space rental, the Maintenance Deck for smelting and building, the drafting room with blueprint review and COMMS) and the game server on Railway. The app and Inara's voice are in 13 languages, including Arabic and Hindi; 191 library books are already in Arabic. What it has cost so far is in section 2.

2. Spent to date (October 2026 to the jam)

Built by Eric with AI models as the development team, so most of the cost so far is time, subscriptions and usage.

Item	What it paid for	Spent
Eric's time	Design, story, direction, testing, every decision: counted at 60 hours a week since Oct 11 (about 210 hours; his real hours run 12-20 a day) at $75 an hour	about $15,750 (in kind)
Anthropic Claude (Pro plan)	Code, game server, library books and tests, documents	$20 (the game's share is about a third)
xAI Grok (X Premium)	Intro video clips and imagery	$0 in this period (earlier months $8)
ElevenLabs (Creator plan, two accounts)	Inara's recorded voice in 12 languages, the intro narration	$44
Sarvam AI	Inara's Hindi voice	about $1.30 (₹115 for 38,900 characters, Nov 3-4)
Railway (Pro plan)	Game server and database, hosting the voice files	$20 (shared with other projects)
Twilio and Resend	Sign-in codes by text and email	$20 (Resend; shared)
Domain and email	risesolutions-llc.com	$0 in this period (no receipt since June)
Internet (Starlink)	The connection everything is built and tested over	$130 (a month; shared)

Item	What it paid for	Spent
Apple developer account	iPhone testing (free Personal Team so far)	$0
Total spent		**about $230 in cash, plus about $15,750 of Eric's time in kind**

Before the game began, Eric spent about $3,000-$4,000 on AI tools (June to September) learning to build with them on earlier projects. That learning made this build possible; it is not counted above.

Rise Solutions' monthly tool stack (all its projects, from the receipts; the game's share is in the table above):

Service	Monthly	What it's for
Anthropic Claude	$20 (Pro), moving to $200 (Max), plus usage	development, writing, the library books
ElevenLabs Creator (two accounts)	$44	recorded voices
X Premium (Grok)	$8	video clips and imagery
Sarvam AI	usage (about $1.30 so far)	Hindi voice
DeepL Pro	$32.50	translation
Railway Pro	$20	game and app servers
Hetzner	about $78	servers and backups
Netlify	$20	websites
Google Cloud	about $5 (usage)	speech and APIs
Resend	$20	email
Metricool	about $22 (list price)	social media scheduling and analytics
Starlink	$130	internet
Porkbun	about $11 a year per domain	domains
Cloudflare	free plan; two other domains, $26 a year	DNS, web delivery, domains
Groq, Deepgram, Twilio, GitHub	free tiers or usage so far	AI speed, speech-to-text, sign-in texts, code
Total	**about $400 a month (about $580 with Claude Max)**	

3. Plan and phases (with a sponsor)

Phase	What's delivered	Time
1. Jam build	Phone build, career ladders and uniforms, library books for all five bars of every career, concept doc, video	to the jam deadline
2. Soft launch	iOS and Android in a few markets; art pass (ships, quarters, characters); onboarding tuned from playtests; analytics	months 1-4
3. Global launch	All stores; PC (Steam) and web; the remaining library books in Arabic, then the other languages; marketing push	months 5-9
4. Live operations	New careers, books and blueprints each season; community; balancing the economy from real play	months 10-12, then ongoing

4. What it takes to scale (12 months, estimates)

Estimates are typical market rates for a small independent studio in late 2026, as low-high ranges, to be confirmed with quotes. They assume a remote team and contractors rather than an office.

Category	Item	12 months (est.)
Team	Eric, founder and creative director, full time	$120,000
Team	Senior game developer (Godot), full time	$90,000-$120,000
Team	Backend and infrastructure engineer, half time	$50,000-$70,000
Art	3D artist: ships, Starship interiors, quarters, characters (contract)	$40,000-$60,000
Art	UI and 2D artist (contract)	$25,000-$35,000
Audio	Music and sound design (contract)	$15,000-$25,000
Audio	Inara's recorded voice in every language (ElevenLabs, Sarvam)	$2,000-$5,000
Quality	QA and playtesting across ages, regions and devices	$20,000-$30,000
Community	Community manager, part time	$25,000-$35,000
Localization	Every library book and test in all 12 of the app's other languages (about 1.7 million words each): AI translation (about $100 a language) plus a native speaker spot-checking each language	$60,000-$100,000

Category	Item	12 months (est.)
	and every test question (about $5,000-$8,000 a language)	
AI tools	Development and writing models: Claude Max ($200 a month) plus usage, and other models	$5,000-$25,000
Servers	Railway game server, database, backups and file delivery, growing with players	$5,000-$25,000
Sign-in	Text codes (about $0.05 each) and email	$2,000-$10,000
Stores	Apple ($99 a year), Google Play ($25 once), Steam ($100 per game)	about $250
Operations	Internet (Starlink, $130 a month)	$1,560
Legal	Trademark clearance and filings (US, EU, UK, UAE); privacy and age review; contracts	$15,000-$40,000
Marketing	Trailer, store pages, streamers and creators, launch campaign	$40,000-$100,000
Payroll	Employer payroll taxes and benefits for the employed team (about 15-25% of their pay)	$25,000-$55,000
Accounting	Bookkeeping and a CPA for tax filings	$3,000-$8,000
Accounting	Accounting software (e.g. QuickBooks)	$500-$1,200
Live operations	Monitoring: server health and an AI watching the logs, the economy and unusual activity around the clock	$3,000-$12,000
Contingency	About 10% for the unexpected	$40,000-$75,000
Total (12 months)		**about $590,000-$955,000**

Taxes. Income tax depends on profit, so it is set aside from revenue rather than budgeted here. App stores collect and pay sales tax and VAT on purchases in most countries, and keep 15-30% of each sale as their fee.

5. How sponsor funding would be used

In order of what moves the game furthest, fastest: 1. **People who multiply what's already built:** a senior Godot developer and a 3D artist, so the working systems get the look and polish of a top store game. 2. **Every book in every language:** the library books and tests in all 12 of the app's other languages, Arabic first for the UAE and Arab-region audience the jam serves, each checked by native speakers. 3. **Playtesting with real players** of every age and background, so the money lessons land and the economy is fair. 4. **Launch:**

store releases on phones, then PC and web, with a marketing push built around Inara and the story. 5. **Running costs** that grow with players: servers, sign-in, voice and AI tools.

A side note on the engine. Stardust - Terra Deleta is built in Godot, which is free and suits a mobile-first game. For the future companion game, Stardust - Terra Nova, we may consider Unreal Engine for a showcase-level 3D world, if Stardust - Terra Deleta is successful enough to offset the cost.

6. Revenue model (for commercial potential)

Free to start, then a small monthly subscription. Anyone can download and play free: the Trainee stage and the first bar of every career. A small monthly subscription (about $4.99 a month, to be set before launch) opens the full game: all five bars of every career, the drafting room and building at the Maintenance Deck.

- **A steady, known income:** a small subscription from players who stay is worth more than chasing new buyers every month, and it grows with the same players whose servers it pays for.
- **Fair by design:** in-game credits are never sold and can never be bought with real money, so no one can pay to win. What players earn, they earn by playing, which is the money lesson the game teaches.
- **Room to reach everyone:** the free start lets students, families and schools play without paying.